

Great Barrier Reef, Queensland

Cairns & surrounds, QLD, Australia UNESCO World Heritage Site Last updated: May 2026

UNESCO status

World Heritage Site

Reef health trend

Critical — declining

Marine park zoning

Active — GBRMPA

QLD minimum wage

AUD \$24.10 / hr

i Destination overview

Size & scope

2,300 km along Queensland's coast; ~3,000 individual reefs, 900 islands. Largest living structure on Earth, visible from space.

Access points

Cairns (CNS) — main hub; also Townsville (TSV), Airlie Beach via Proserpine (PPP), Bundaberg (BDB), Hamilton Island (HTI).

Best season

May–October (clearest water, warm temps). Avoid December–February (cyclone season, stinger season). Turtle hatching: Jan–Mar.

Governing body

Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Authority (GBRMPA / Reef Authority) under the Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Act 1975. Joint management with the Queensland Government.

Key legal frameworks

Great Barrier Reef Marine Park Act 1975 · EPBC Act 1999 · Great Barrier Reef Intergovernmental Agreement 2009 · Reef 2050 Long-Term Sustainability Plan

! Sustainability challenges & current status

Critical: The 2024–2025 AIMS report found the largest annual coral cover decline in 39 years of monitoring. 48% of surveyed reefs declined in coral cover. The 2024 mass bleaching event was the fifth since 2016, affecting 74% of reefs surveyed — the most extensive on record. Coral cover dropped up to 30% in some regions.

Primary threats

- 1. Climate change** — ocean heat stress is the dominant driver. Sea temperatures in Jan–Mar 2024 were the warmest in 400 years.
- 2. Crown-of-thorns starfish** — GBRMPA's control program culled 11,640 hectares in 2023–24.
- 3. Water quality** — agricultural runoff from 35 catchments.
- 4. Tropical cyclones** — increasing intensity compounds bleaching damage.

UNESCO risk

In 2023, the Australian Government committed AUD \$4.4 billion in reef protection investments, gillnet bans by 2027, and no-fishing zones across one-third of the site to address UNESCO recommendations.

Positive programs

Reef 2050 Plan · Blueprint for Climate Resilience 2030 · Reef Restoration and Adaptation Program (RRAP) · Tourism Reef Protection Initiative (25,671 reef health surveys) · Indigenous Futures coral restoration program

Orange Journeys monitoring note: Monitor GBRMPA seasonal reports and avoid directing clients to areas with active bleaching or crown-of-thorns outbreaks.



Biodiversity & protected species

Key wildlife

1,500+ fish species · 1,200+ coral species · 6 of 7 marine turtle species · Humpback & dwarf minke whales · Dugongs · Dolphins · 215+ bird species on islands

Marine turtles (all 6)

Protected — EPBC Act

Dugong

Protected — national & international

Whales & dolphins

Protected — mandatory distances

Coral (all species)

CITES Appendix II

Giant clams

CITES Appendix II

Reef sharks

No-take zone species

Forbidden souvenirs: It is illegal to take, damage or sell coral (including dead coral), protected shells, turtle products, or any item derived from CITES-listed species.



Traditional Owners & Indigenous considerations

Sea Country

The Great Barrier Reef spans the sea Country of numerous Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander groups. Traditional Owners hold cultural, spiritual, and inherent rights and responsibilities for the Reef and its future.

Key programs

Traditional Use of Marine Resources Agreements (TUMRAs) · Indigenous Sea Rangers program · Indigenous Futures coral restoration project · Reef Trust Partnership (\$51.8M+ invested with 1,200+ Traditional Owners across 55 reef protection projects)

Cultural protocols

Always acknowledge Traditional Owners when visiting reef areas. Seek permission and follow guidance before visiting sites of cultural significance. Respect restrictions on photography and access at culturally sensitive locations.

Preferred operators: Prioritise Indigenous-led operators such as Dreamtime Dive & Snorkel (Australia's first Indigenous tourism operator on the GBR) and GBR Biology, which offer cultural interpretation alongside reef experiences.



Marine Park zoning & regulations

Operator permits

All tourism operators must hold a GBRMPA permit. Orange Journeys should only contract High Standard Tourism Operators (HSTOs) — operators recognised by GBRMPA as operating in an ecologically sustainable manner. Verify at gbrmpa.gov.au before contracting.

No-take zones

At least one-third of the Marine Park is designated no-take. Zone rules must be confirmed for each specific site before excursion design.

Master Reef Guides

82 Master Reef Guides are accredited across the reef. Preference should be given to tours using Master Reef Guides at sensitive sites.

✓ Visitor code of conduct

DO

- ✓ Use reef-safe, TGA-approved sunscreen
- ✓ Wear a wetsuit or stinger suit
- ✓ Stay 1m+ from coral and giant clams
- ✓ Stay 3–5m from all free-swimming wildlife
- ✓ Use moorings instead of anchoring where available
- ✓ Listen to crew safety briefings
- ✓ Use the buddy system when snorkelling
- ✓ Report coral damage or pollution to GBRMPA
- ✓ Support citizen science (Reef Census, Project Manta)
- ✓ Choose HSTO-certified operators

DO NOT

- ✗ Touch, stand on, or kick coral
- ✗ Chase, touch, or block marine wildlife
- ✗ Feed fish — alters natural behaviour
- ✗ Take coral, shells, or any marine material
- ✗ Discharge rubbish, fuel or plastics overboard
- ✗ Disturb nesting seabirds on islands
- ✗ Anchor on coral — use sand or mud only
- ✗ Buy souvenirs made from coral or turtle species
- ✗ Approach whale sharks or whales under 30m
- ✗ Enter green (preservation) zones

Boating rules: All vessel sewage must be managed appropriately — overboard discharge is illegal. Operators must reduce speed near dugongs, turtles and dolphins. Safe distance from whales: 300m (100m if approached by whale).

🏠 Local economic network

Indigenous-led Dreamtime Dive & Snorkel — Australia's first Indigenous reef tourism venture. Cultural storytelling, marine biology, Sea Country interpretation.
Cairns-based · Master Reef Guide accredited

Indigenous-led GBR Biology — cultural presentations, glass-bottom boat tours, reef education with Traditional Owner knowledge and Indigenous Ecological Knowledge sharing.
Gunggandji Sea Country · Education & research focus

HSTO certified Passions of Paradise — owner-operated since 1987. Supports Daintree tree-planting, crown-of-thorns control, reef health surveys, Project AWARE donations.
Cairns-based · Strong sustainability track record

Master Reef Guide Ocean Safari (Cape Tribulation) — small-group snorkelling at Mackay Reef with marine biologists and Master Reef Guides.
Cape Tribulation · Low-impact group sizes

Donation opportunities

Great Barrier Reef Foundation · Project AWARE · Cairns Turtle Rehabilitation Centre · Reef Restoration Foundation

\$ Labour standards & wages

QLD / National minimum wage (FY2024–25)

AUD \$24.10 per hour

Tourism & hospitality award

Check Fair Work Australia for current award rates by role

Supplier check

All contracted excursion providers should confirm compliance with Fair Work Act 2009 employment conditions. Include this as a standard clause in all GBR excursion contracts.

↑ Orange Journeys engagement & policy influencing

Relevant bodies

GBRMPA · Great Barrier Reef Foundation · Tourism and Events Queensland · Cairns Regional Council · Association of Marine Park Tourism Operators (AMPTO)

Conservation contribution

Recommended: direct a portion of per-booking revenue from GBR packages to the Great Barrier Reef Foundation or Reef Restoration Foundation. Document annually.

Certification opportunity: Only contract GBRMPA High Standard Tourism Operators (HSTOs) for GBR excursions. Verify HSTO status at gbrmpa.gov.au before signing any new excursion contracts.

Sources: GBRMPA / Reef Authority (gbrmpa.gov.au) · AIMS Long-Term Monitoring Program 2025 · DCCEEW Traditional Owner Reef Protection · Great Barrier Reef Foundation · University of Sydney (2025 bleaching study) · Fair Work Australia. Review and update at minimum every 12 months, or following any significant reef event. Prepared by Orange Journeys sustainability team.